

The original Gympie Baptists—Three strikes!

By Rev Dr David Parker © June 2026

Acknowledgements and abbreviations

The main sources of information about the early Baptist presence in Gympie used in this paper were the *Nashville Times*, 1868, and its successor, the *Gympie Times*, 1868-1919, and to a lesser extent, other newspapers, which were accessed via Trove, the online library database of the National Library of Australia, <https://trove.nla.gov.au/>

Information was also gathered from Queensland State Archives; State Library of Queensland; Queensland Government Museum of Lands, Mapping and Surveying; Gympie Regional Libraries; Gympie Family History Society; Gympie Gold Mining and Historical Museum; Mrs Del Parker, Townsville; Mr Thom Blake Historian (<https://www.thomblake.com.au/>) Brisbane; Baptist Church Archives Queensland.

Particular help with locations was obtained in the maps of Mary Street, Gympie and of the One Mile compiled in 1869 by Clarendon Stuart, the well-known Queensland surveyor who was resident in Gympie at the time (<https://www.daao.org.au/bio/clarendon-stuart/biography/> accessed 31 May 2026). A paper copy of the former was supplied by Mrs Del Parker and a digital copy from the Gympie Regional Libraries. A digital copy of the latter was also supplied by Gympie Regional Libraries. An annotated portion of the One Mile is on display at the Gympie Gold Mining and Historical Museum.

Unattributed photographs in the text of this document are by the author, with dates where available.

For details of the probable location of the Baptist Church at One Mile 1869-1872, see the appendix.

Abbreviations

ADEB - Australian Dictionary of Evangelical Biography

GT - Gympie Times and Mary River Mining Gazette

MC - Maryborough Chronicle

MGEv - The Maryborough and Gympie Evangelist

NT - *Nashville Times*, *Gympie and Mary River Mining Gazette*

QB - The Queensland Baptist

QF - The Queensland Freeman



Introduction

Gympie is a name to conjure with in the history of Queensland! Rich supplies of gold were discovered there in late 1867, which were credited with saving the new colony from financial disaster! Given the economic conditions of the day, it was certainly a valuable and timely find, but the fate of Baptists in the area, although commencing as early as the gold discoveries themselves, was far less memorable.



Representation of Curtis Nugget on display at Gympie Gold Mining and Historical Museum (6 May 2026)

The city (current population 22,000) is located about 150 kms north of Brisbane on the Mary River, and about 130 kms from its mouth. The area was thickly wooded at first, inhabited by the Gubbi Gubbi people, and then from 1840s, it became part of the Widgee pastoral area. Timber getting, especially cedar, was also a prosperous industry. Gympie was proclaimed a town in 1880 and a city in 1905.

In the late 1860s, Queensland was suffering from the effects of a prolonged drought and extremely difficult economic conditions. Motivated by a reward offered by the government of Queensland for the discovery of gold, an experienced prospector, James Nash (1834-1913), travelled into the district from Nanango in October 1867, and immediately found small amounts of alluvial gold in a gully near Caledonian Hill, close to the current Town Hall.

The initial finds were soon followed up with more promising discoveries, so Nash reported to the authorities on 16 October, and the rush to the 'Upper Mary goldfield' began—first from Maryborough about 90 km away at the mouth of the Mary River, and then from everywhere. The location was initially named Nashville, and then Gympie (after a local stinging shrub). The population soon swelled to around 30,000.

The alluvial gold was soon exhausted, but then deep reefs of high-quality gold were discovered, mining of which lasted about 50 years. The peak of production was in 1903, after which there was a steady decline until viable mining ceased in the 1920s, only to be revived again in the 1980s in a modernised form. The 'Curtis nugget', the largest in Queensland history, producing 906 ounces of gold, was discovered on 6 February 1868 close to the location of



Former Disciples/Church of Christ, 9 Crescent Rd Gympie (2023)

Nash's original finds, and was valued at more than £3600 (perhaps well over \$3 million today). For 60 years until 1927, about 3.5 million ounces of gold were extracted, with more than 230 companies in production and shafts nearly 1000 metres in depth.

The first Baptists in Gympie 1867

Baptists were in Gympie from the very beginning, but, as with many of the miners, their fortunes fluctuated!

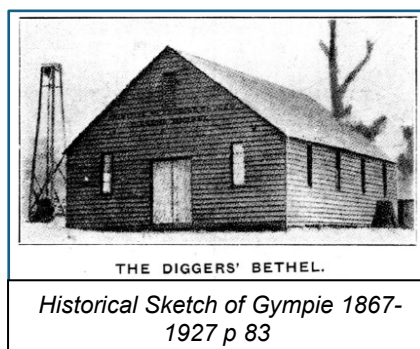
When news of the original finds became public, the Christian churches of Maryborough were quick to respond. A report in the *Maryborough Chronicle* on Christmas Day 1867, under the heading 'Mary River Gold Field', indicated that 'some steps are being taken towards keeping the Sunday as a day of rest.'¹

Worship services had been conducted by the Presbyterian minister, Rev J B West, as well as several Wesleyan preachers, and it was noted that 'Mr Godson, Baptist minister of Maryborough, was also on the ground.'² A later report suggested that the first service in Gympie was conducted as early as November 1867 by Mr Edwards, a Primitive Methodist local preacher.³

¹ *The Maryborough Chronicle* 12 Sept 1868 p 2 noted that 'The Sabbath is now marked by an entire cessation of mining operations, and churches are attended by large congregations.'

² See also David Parker, 'The man who saved Maryborough Baptists – WT Godson' 2026 <https://www.bhsq.org/bhq/papers/>; *Maryborough Chronicle* 25 Dec 1867 p 2

³ GT 3 Nov 1868

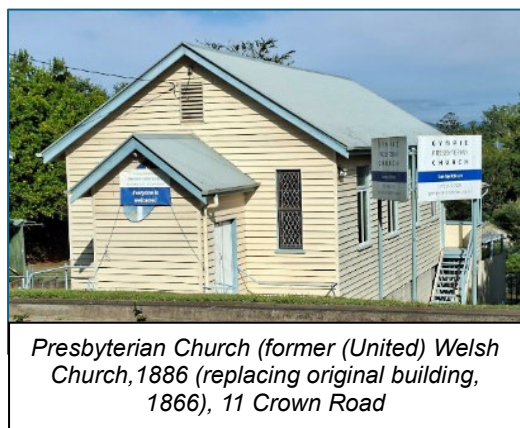


It was also reported that 'A subscription is being got up to build a large place for a church, to be open to the use of all denominations.' On 16 February 1868 such a building was opened in Nash Street,⁴ close to the corner of Channon Street, near the then Croaker's Northumberland Hotel. It was known as 'The Diggers' Bethel'⁵ and was in regular use in the months that followed, especially by the Primitive Methodists. It was described as 'neatly and substantially built.'⁶ It even attracted the protection of the law in 1869 when two people were prosecuted for ringing the bell and fixing 'certain placards' to the door. Reports indicated that 'the offence of posting theatrical bills upon the doors of place of worship was a serious one.' The fine was 10 shillings in each case, plus costs.⁷

Mr Godson had already been in Gympie a little earlier because it was reported that at Nashville on 18 December 1867 he had conducted the marriage of Mr John Hu(l)lyer, a butcher of Gympie Creek, late of Cambridge UK, and Miss Flora Lama of that locality (late of M'Cloud Scotland).⁸ This was long remembered as probably the earliest marriage on the gold field!⁹ On 29 September 1868 at Maryborough, he also conducted the marriage of John Nash, the brother of James Nash.¹⁰ He may have conducted another wedding of a Gympie man on 8 November 1883, although the location is not stated.¹¹

Nothing more is heard of any further involvement in Gympie by Godson at the time, but he did eventually retire to that town, and died there in 1888. There was no Baptist activity in Gympie then, and he was associated with the inauguration of the Disciples/Churches of Christ in August 1886, having been attracted to that new faith by his increased interest in baptism in his later years. His funeral service took place from the newly-erected Disciples (Church of Christ) building, located at 9 Crescent Road, Gympie.

The gold rush church at the One Mile 1868-72



As soon as the rush started, many different churches were established in Gympie, even in multiple centres in different parts of the town. The Baptist were part of this initiative, but although there were promising developments at first, there would be disappointment!

An itinerant Baptist preacher, Rev J J Westwood of Melbourne, visited Gympie and preached at the Diggers' Bethel on March 22, 1868, and also in the open air.¹² There is no record of contact with any existing local Baptists or other church groups.

However, there must have been a number of Baptists in the town, perhaps even loosely organised into different groups, because there was a notice in the *Nashville Times* of 15 April 1868 inviting 'Members of Baptist Churches resident on the Gympie

⁴ NT 15 Feb 1868 p 4

⁵ The site is marked on the Stuart map of Gympie (1869) as 'Primitive (sic) (Methodist) Church' and is now occupied by Gympie Regional Council Planning and Development department car park or the former School of Arts (Gympie Regional Gallery); *Maryborough Chronicle* 25 Aug 1868 p 2; NT 9 May 1868 p 3; *Daily Mercury Mackay*, 21 Feb 1936 p 9. The Wesleyan Methodists also opened a basic building further south on Channon Street in August 1868, which was later replaced by the existing extensive buildings opposite, at 14 Channon Street..

⁶ MC 12 Sept 1868 p 2; it is the 'chapel first erected' and 'stands on a site near Croaker's Northumberland Hotel.' A similar building was located 'at the One-mile' for the Congregationalists. There were many reports that several denominations used 'Diggers' Bethel' at first (although none are actually documented), but it (if it was indeed the building intended originally) soon become the home of the Primitive Methodists, as indicated on the Stuart map, 1869.

⁷ GT 5 May 1869 p 2. The bell was reported as ending up at St Andrew's Presbyterian Church in Gympie (Ray Kerkhove, *Soul Havens: The Story of Spiritual Sanctuaries on the Sunshine Coast* Enoggera, Q 2003 p 33)

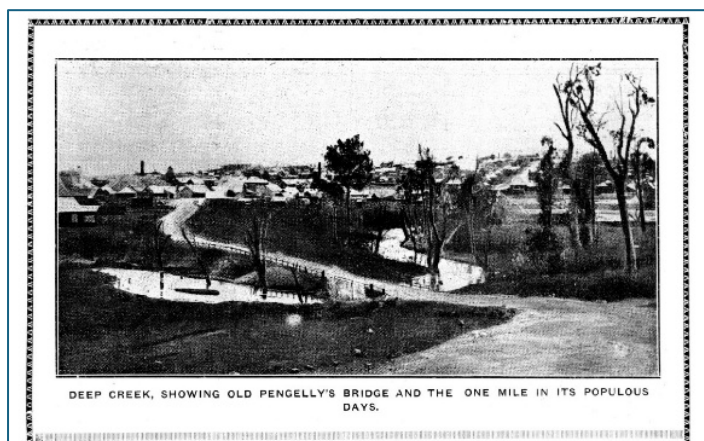
⁸ MC 28 Dec 1867

⁹ Brisbane Courier 12 April 1927

¹⁰ MC 1 Oct 1868

¹¹ GT 14 Nov 1883

¹² NT 21 Mar 1868 p 2



DEEP CREEK, SHOWING OLD PENGELLY'S BRIDGE AND THE ONE MILE IN ITS POPULOUS DAYS.

*One Mile areas seen from Deep Creek
(Historical Sketch of Gympie 1867-1927 p 22)*

Gold-fields' who were 'desirous of UNION' (emphasis original) to meet on Sunday 10 April at the Mr Costin's store in Mary Street, Gympie.¹³ An accompanying paragraph called on 'the members of the Baptist denomination' who '*are in favour of a union of the different churches*' (emphasis added) to support the gathering.¹⁴ There is no record of the outcome of that meeting, but at the end of the year, Baptists were a recognizable community, requesting the appointment of a representative to the cemetery trust.¹⁵

Then in a few weeks' time, on 11 February 1869, an application was lodged in the name of the 'Denomination of Particular Baptists Strict Communion' to purchase a block of land fronting One Mile Road for use as a church.¹⁶ This initiative did not arise from the same wider group

as the earlier one seeking a 'union' of various Baptists, although two of the original four names, William Jeremiah Daniell and James Pyne (Payne) appeared on this application. They were identified as trustees for the 'Denomination of Particular Baptists Strict Communion.'¹⁷ The land was 100 ft wide and 200 ft deep in a north-easterly direction with buildings on it, and was probably located at the current 42-44 Red Hill Road, Red Hill.¹⁸ The process was duly completed, and on 31 March 1869 the building was in use for public gatherings as well as for church purposes.¹⁹



*Primitive Methodist Church (Diggers' Bethel) with bell tower marked, located on Nash Street, with Croakers Hotel and Cobb & Co depot adjacent
(Stuart Map of Gympie, 1869)*

This block, which was valued in the application at £40, was identified as the former residence of Dr Bull²⁰, who had relocated away from the One Mile to central Gympie only late in the previous year. It was described in the sale advertisement as 'a substantially-built slab and weatherboard house, containing four rooms and a kitchen' with a 'large slab stable, and hay or coach house' in a 'full-sized area, substantially fenced.' It even came with all of 'the doctor's dispensary, with a very useful stock of drugs, and all the necessary appliances'! It could be used as a 'residence suitable for any gentleman with a small family,

¹³ And again on 18 April 1868. This location was about opposite Tattersalls Hotel (the current Rivers and Gympie Office Supplies 34 and 32 Mary St). Costin's would have been on the opposite northern side of the street at 29 Mary St, close to Mama Dees Kitchen.

¹⁴ NT 15 April 1868 p 2

¹⁵ GT 22 Dec 1868. The meeting was held in the (United) Welsh (Presbyterian) Church, 11 Crown Rd, now the Presbyterian Church. The first building dates from 1868, and it was replaced in 1886.

¹⁶ QSA ITM22466; see also SW Nickerson, Rev Benjamin Gilmore Wilson, Queensland Baptist Founding Father (Baptist Historical Society of Queensland, 1998) p 81. There were numerous other applications at that time for land under Clause 38 of the Crown Lands Alienation Act 1868 (31 Vic No. 46), but the Baptist application did not cite this authority.

¹⁷ The other names were HA Harwood, of whom nothing is known except a letter from a person of that name in New Chum, near Ipswich, and also Joshua Jenyns who does not seem to be the person of the same name who was well known in the Baptist circles in Brisbane and Beaudesert and who wrote an earlier, highly personalised history of Baptists in the colony, entitled, 'Fruit from the tree of experience' (BHSQ 1996)

¹⁸ See appendix for a discussion of this location.

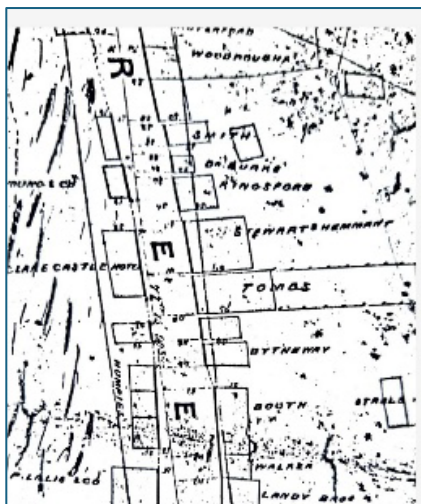
¹⁹ GT 31 March 1869 p 2

²⁰ Dr Bull, formerly of Ballarat, Victoria, had arrived in the colony in August 1868, and made his way to Gympie, setting up in the One Mile district soon after. He did not remain long in the area.

or lucky reef proprietor, or might be converted into a good business place.²¹

The One Mile village area (located about that distance from Mary Street in a south-easterly direction) was a thriving and progressive commercial, residential and industrial centre at the time, surrounded by many diggings. It centred on the current location of Brisbane Road (formerly One Mile Road) between the intersections with Phoenix and Graham Streets, south of the One Mile School.

There was also much activity extending further back northward along One Mile Road up the sharp incline of Red Hill Road over the (later) railway crossing and up to the location of the Hibernian Hall (demolished), Rechabite Hall (now a commercial premise), Presbyterian Church (now Uniting Church), Methodist Church (opposite, demolished), and Oddfellows Hall (now a Karate centre), as well as other businesses and private homes. The rise to the Rechabite Hall was about 130ft or 40 metres from One Mile gully near the school.²²

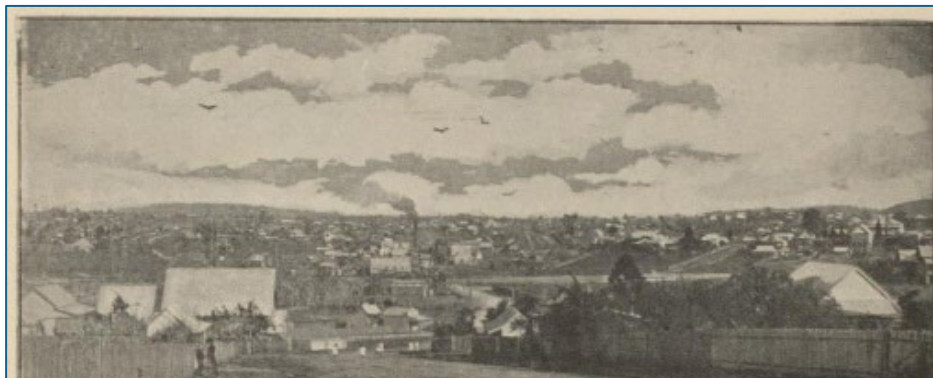


Detail of Stuart map of Mary Street Gympie, 1869, showing the Kingsford premises at approx. 79 Mary Street

This initiative to establish a Baptist presence was linked to the Jireh Particular Baptist Church, which was located in Gipps Street, Fortitude Valley, Brisbane. It had been constituted in 1862 as a breakaway for spiritual and pastoral reasons from the original Wharf Street Baptist Church (established 1855). The pastor of this new church was John Kingsford, who had arrived in Brisbane early in 1861 to join his brother, Richard Ash Kingford, in running their successful Queen Street drapery business. R A Kingsford had been a leading figure in the Wharf Street church since its inception, but had not joined the group who split off to start the Jireh church, even though his brother, a lay preacher of many years' experience, became the pastor.

However, as early as March 1868, R A and J Kingsford, like many other enterprising businessmen, had expanded their commercial interests to Gympie to cash in on the gold rush.²³ They had two stores—one in the main part of Gympie (previously owned by O'Sullivan and Rael), probably at 79 Mary Street,²⁴ and another in the more progressive One Mile area.²⁵ The latter was described as nearly opposite the One Mile Post Office.²⁶ It was probably at the current 16 Brisbane Road on the east side of the former One Mile Road, between the intersections of the Phoenix and Graham Streets.²⁷ One of their managers was WJ Daniell.

The first anniversary of this church was held in January of 1870.²⁸ The report, presented at this gathering and



One Mile Gympie, Wm Lees, *Goldfields of Queensland: Gympie Goldfield 1868 to 1898* (Brisbane: Outridge Printing Company, 1899) p 8

published in the *Gympie Times*, indicated that the church had begun meeting for worship in February 1868, initially in the Kingsford's Gympie store in Mary Street, and then in the larger store owned by W J Costin. It had then moved to the Kingsford store at One Mile. These were more or less private gatherings, but the acquisition of the land and

²¹ GT 5 Dec 1868

²² See *Queensland Geological Survey Topographical Map of Gympie and Environs* by B Dunstan 1910, Sheet 11 Gympie and Environs.

²³ NT 11 March 1868 p 2

²⁴ NT 4 March 1868 p 1

²⁵ MC 10 Dec 1872

²⁶ The Post Office was later relocated higher up above flood level to Graham Street. Its original location is not marked on the Stuart map of 1869.

²⁷ This property is marked on the Stuart map and is highlighted on the version of this map on display at the Gympie Mining and Historical Museum.

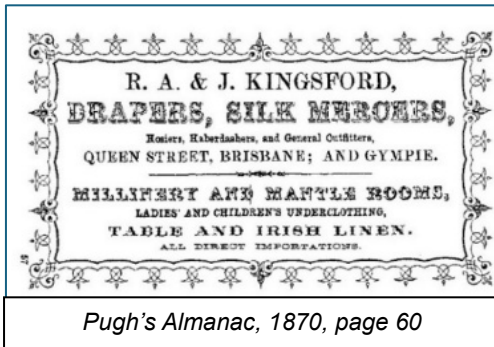
²⁸ GT 19 Jan 1870, 26 Jan 1870

building on One Mile Road late in the year meant that the church could go public.

The first such services were held on 27 December 1868, with four different lay men taking turns at presiding. The church was formally constituted on Thursday 28 October 1869, with 12 members, six each male and female. Attendance at services fluctuated, weekly prayer meetings were not so well attended and a Sabbath School, established in January 1869, flourished for a while but soon failed because many children were already enrolled at other schools.

This looked promising, but it would all come to nothing!

In March 1870, after many days of rain, the entire Gympie goldfields area, including the One Mile and the burgeoning town around Mary Street, was hit with a catastrophic flood. In particular, the impact at the One Mile where the Kingsford store and the Baptist church were located was very severe.



Pugh's Almanac, 1870, page 60

Press reports of 19 March 1870 said that 'the whole of the One Mile and the greater part of the town of Gympie [were] under water' and that boat voyages were being made from the Particular Baptist Church near the One Mile to the Monkland gold reef over houses, mining claims and roads. Four days later, on 16 March, a large portion of the One Mile township was still submerged 'from R A and J Kingsford's store to a considerable distance up the hill on which the Baptist Chapel stands.' Even a few days later, on 19 March, there was no relief as 'the whole of One Mile and greater part of town was still under water, including the Kingsford premises.'

This flood was devastating for the One Mile area, both commercially and residentially. Nothing more was heard of the Baptist church as an organisation after this, although the 1871 census reported there were still 59 male and 53 female Baptists in the area.²⁹ In the circumstances, it was not surprising that by October of that year, the Kingsford business at One Mile was up for sale (and presumably the Mary Street premises as well). Instructions for this development came from Mr Pyne who represented the Kingsfords.³⁰

In August 1872, a report appeared in the newspaper indicating that the Baptist church building would be sold to the Hibernian Society.³¹ The transaction was completed by December 1872,³² and with it came the end of the initial attempt to establish a Baptist church in Gympie. However, it would not be the last.

In the meantime, Gympie's fortunes fluctuated considerably. As early as May 1868 there was sudden reduction in activity as people rushed to a new find at nearby Kilkivan, and then in the 1870s there were significant rushes to fields in North Queensland at places such Charters Towers, Palmer River and then later at Mount Morgan and Croydon. All of these developments affected the town generally and the small community of Baptists in particular.

²⁹ GT 27 April 1872

³⁰ GT 15 Oct 1870

³¹ GT 24 Aug 1872 p 3; The title was transferred on Sept 14, 1872 to John H McGurrin (or M'Gurrin), trustee for the Hibernian Society (*Gympie's Jubilee 1867-1917*; *Gympie in its cradle days* (Gympie: Gympie and District Historical Society, 1985) p 12.

³² Maryborough Chronicle, 7 Dec 1872

The Weller- Barnett church 1887—1890

Rev W Bonser 1887-88

Despite the failure of the first attempt to establish a church, Gympie had not been forgotten as a place where Baptists could be represented. But the number of other denominations, already extensive, had recently been expanded to include the Salvation Army who set up their first activity in September 1886.³³



Hibernian Australasian Catholic Benefit Society (HACB) Hall, 42-44 Red Hill Road (Historical Sketch of Gympie, 1867-1927 edited by A.L. Stumm, W.C. Woolgar, and C.S. Trudgian, pp 94-96, 97

The Queensland Baptist newspaper, *The Queensland Freeman*, often referred to Gympie as one of many towns in Queensland where Baptist work should begin. For example, in 1883, prominent Baptist leader, George H Buzacott (who was BAQ secretary 1883-1888³⁴) made a private tour of central Queensland, which included a short stay in Gympie. In reporting on his travels, he pointed out that there was only one Baptist church north of Brisbane (at Rockhampton) and he called on Baptists to take up the opportunities that existed elsewhere to extend their footprint.³⁵ Buzacott informed his readers, 'Gympie is an exceedingly pretty place and the people there are very sociable.'

There are churches of almost all denominations but no Baptist.³⁶ The 1881 Census results had shown 81 Baptists in Gympie, 36 males and 45 females.³⁷

In a later address promoting home missions, Rev William Whale, the influential minister of the Wharf Street Baptist Church, remarked how strange it was that Baptists could take such a keen interest in mission work in distant locations overseas, like China and Africa, yet there were places in Queensland, including Gympie, which were much closer to home, yet, he said, 'we take no care' for them!³⁸ In 1886 the President of the BAQ, Rev William Higlett, also visited both Maryborough and Gympie looking for opportunities to extend the work of the Association.³⁹

In the meantime, the link with Jireh church in Brisbane had been fleetingly renewed in 1885 when a person from Gympie was baptised at that church.⁴⁰ And in 1888, the death of Mr W J Daniell who had been a key figure in the earlier Baptist church in Gympie, was reported.⁴¹

But there was significant development taking place in Gympie. In late October 1887, a notice appeared in the *Gympie Times* announcing that Rev William Bonser, the minister of the Maryborough Baptist Church would conduct some meetings in the Oddfellows Hall in Gympie. The notice said that he would 'meet all desirous of forming themselves into a Baptist Church. All Baptists earnestly invited to rally to the meeting' and for them to 'Bring your own Sankey's Hymn Book'!

He made several visits over coming weeks, using the Welsh Church in Crown Road as well. One of his topics was, 'Does Baptism save us?' and the publicity said the meeting was open to all, but 'especially Baptists.' He also addressed a public meeting on 'Mr Spurgeon and his great work in London.'⁴²

³³ GT 30 Sept 1886 p 2

³⁴ David Parker, 'Baptist Union of Queensland Secretaries; G H Buzacott, 1840-1918', *Queensland Baptist Forum*, No 122 Nov 2025, pp 2-4, 7

³⁵ QF October 1883 p 6

³⁶ QF October 1883 p 5

³⁷ QF July 1882 p 7

³⁸ QF 14 May 1887 p 4

³⁹ QB June 1886 p 3

⁴⁰ QF May 1885 p 13

⁴¹ QF April 1888 p 11

⁴² GT 13 Dec 1887

TO THE BAPTISTS ON GYMPIE.

WILLIAM BONSOR, Baptist Minister, Maryborough, will PREACH in the Oddfellows' Hall, on MONDAY and THURSDAY, 24th and 27th inst. Service commences at 7.

WILLIAM BONSOR will meet all desirous of forming themselves into a Baptist Church. All Baptists earnestly invited to rally to the Meeting.

Collection after Public Meeting to defray expenses.

Bring your Sankey's Hymn Book.

Gympie Times 22 Oct 1887 p 2

Although Bonser reported that attendance at these gatherings was encouraging, he decided that the distance of Gympie from Maryborough was too great for him to maintain regular contact. However, he did manage to visit periodically, conducting services and public meetings in various halls. It seems that the local Baptists continued to meet and were able to conduct some services on their own.

This was the start of a remarkable period of short but intense activity, supported now by the Baptist Association (Union) of Queensland (BAQ). This denominational organisation had been formed in 1877 to bring the existing independent churches in the colony together, and especially to provide an structured way to plant churches and conduct other beneficial activities cooperatively.⁴³ The Association would provide welcome resources for Gympie over coming months, but the venture would come to

an end almost as soon as it had started, and leave the town again without a Baptist presence for almost another decade.

Interest by the BAQ was boosted in the following April (1888) when Rev William Whale, as the Association President, carried out an extensive tour, including Maryborough and Gympie in the south, and then Rockhampton, Townsville and other northern places. Travelling to Gympie with Mr Bonser on April 9, he met with local Baptists, including the secretary Mr Nott, and acquainted himself with the town and its prospects.⁴⁴ He preached at a service in the Oddfellows Hall.⁴⁵

Subsequently, a report was presented to the Baptist Association, which recommended pastors be sent to Gympie as well to two other northern towns, Townsville and Charters Towers. There would be financial support for an initial period and a review after six months to evaluate progress and prospects. The man selected for Gympie was Mr A G Weller, and he was commissioned at Wharf Street Baptist Church on Monday 7 August 1888.

Rev A G Weller 1888-1890



*Rev A G Weller
(Baptist Church
Archives, Qld)*

Alfred George Weller was born in Ramsgate Kent, England in 1861 and, after early links with the Congregational church, became associated with C H Spurgeon's London Metropolitan Tabernacle. He attended the Christian Workers Training Class there. When he moved to Brisbane in 1887, he was recommended by Spurgeon to associate himself with the Wharf Street church, then under the leadership of Rev William Whale, who was a Spurgeon's Pastors' College graduate. Weller assisted Whale in city mission and pastoral work, while continuing his ministerial studies. He also became the initial secretary of the first Christian Endeavour Society to be formed in Australia, based at the Wharf Street church.

Weller, then in his late 20s and an energetic and capable single young man, left for Gympie on Friday 10 August 1888, a few days after his commissioning, and he soon made his presence felt. Special services were held at the Rechabites Hall on 19 August 1888 to mark the commencement of his ministry.⁴⁶ One of the first developments was to adopt the use of the name 'Gympie Tabernacle' for the church – a reflection of Weller's home church, Spurgeon's Metropolitan Tabernacle.⁴⁷ This was the first time this title had been used by Baptists in Queensland, although it was commonly used elsewhere, especially in Tasmania where many Spurgeon's College pastors had been serving. Soon, in 1890, it would be adopted for the church when it relocated to its new site in Upper Edward Street.⁴⁸

Positive reports of the development of the nascent Gympie Tabernacle appeared in the following months indicating that a Sunday School had been commenced, an organ had been obtained to enhance worship services, and a building fund commenced. Activities included ladies' work, prayer meetings, a young men's training class

⁴³ For a general history, see *Pressing on with the Gospel: the Story of Baptists in Queensland 1855–2005*, edited by David Parker, with L J Ball and S W Nickerson, Baptist Historical Society of Queensland, 2005.

⁴⁴ GT 11 March 1939 reported on the Jubilee of the church and provided some additional historical details, not all of which can be reconciled with information from the day.

⁴⁵ QF May 1888 p 8

⁴⁶ GT 23 Aug 1888

⁴⁷ GT 8 Sept 1888

⁴⁸ See *The Week* 1 Sept 1888

(modelled on the system Weller had experienced at Spurgeon's Tabernacle), a boys' club, temperance work, and a cricket team. A Flower Service was held to raise funds for the local hospital with the promise of endowing a bed.

Weller was registered as a marriage celebrant and conducted a few ceremonies including one for the daughter of the church secretary. He was recognized as a good preacher, showing 'originality of thought' in an 'excellent' address at the twentieth anniversary of the Wesleyan church. It was entitled, 'The Gospel Mine',⁴⁹ and it revealed that he had acquainted himself very well with local industry. He was described as 'very original speaker' at the Baptist Flower Service on 6 January 1889,⁵⁰ where a hymn written by him had also been used. A full summary of one of his sermons (on 1 Peter 2:7) appeared in the local press.⁵¹



Source – *Historical Sketch of Gympie*, p 94. Now IKD Karate Australia Martial Arts Centre, 11 Red Hill Road

In addition to his local pastoral and community work, Weller collaborated with the pastor of the Maryborough church in producing a free joint newspaper, called the *Maryborough and Gympie Evangelist*, issued monthly and carrying news of the churches, and various inspirational and evangelistic articles.

In addition to these extraordinary efforts for the Baptist church, Weller also involved himself in other local activities and worthy causes, including fellowship with other churches, the British and Foreign Bible Society (serving as president of the local branch from September 1889) and the temperance movement.⁵² He even spoke at a rally in support of the London Dock Strike of August 1889. This was a matter with which he had intimate knowledge from his earlier life in that city. He had only a few weeks earlier given a well-received public lecture, 'A peep at London Slums' in which he had presented a 'striking picture' of conditions.⁵³

He also travelled frequently, including participation in an evangelistic mission at the Maryborough Baptist Church.⁵⁴ He visited Brisbane on several occasions, sometimes speaking at Wharf Street, his former church, and involving himself in denominational matters.

A key point was reached early in 1889 at the end of the initial six-month period, when a decision was necessary about the future of the work. Remarkable progress had been made in a short time. In addition to the eight people who had supported the original application to the BAQ for a pastor, 11 more had since been added by baptism, there were another three ready for that step, and there were four enquirers, not to mention those who had transferred to the church from elsewhere.⁵⁵ There was also a Sunday School of 30 children under the care of six teachers, and

⁴⁹ GT 15 June 1889; *Methodist Leader* 1 Aug 1889 p 8; notes in MGEv Aug 1889 p 1

⁵⁰ GT 8 Jan 1889

⁵¹ The *Colonist*, Maryborough 7 Dec 1889, and MC 30 Nov 1889 p 4. For other advertisements, see GT 13 Oct 1888 p 2, GT 15 Nov 1888 p 2 and GT 17 Nov 1888 p 4.

⁵² GM 11 Sept 1889

⁵³ GM 24 June 1889 p 2

⁵⁴ MC 8 July 1888

⁵⁵ GT 21 Feb 1889 p 3



Rechabite Hall, Red Hill Road (Historical Sketch of Gympie p 98) and current commercial building on-site (Google Maps Street View of 23 Red Hill Road (modified) 14 June 2026

eight in a young men's class.⁵⁶ So at a meeting of 30 members on 18 February 1889, there was no hesitation in formally constituting the church and calling Weller to remain as pastor. A decision was also made to join the Baptist Association.

Baptisms and the Disciples Church

There was a steady flow of conversions, and baptisms took place frequently, but not having a building with a baptistry of its own, the church needed to make other arrangements. On Boxing Day 1888, three baptisms were conducted in the Maryborough church. There were five more candidates waiting, and the only hindrance was the lack of physical facilities, reported Mr Weller.⁵⁷

Then a creative solution was tested out. On 15 February 1889, four baptisms were held in the Disciples (Church of Christ) building at 9 Crescent Road, with which Rev WT Godson had been associated a little earlier. Weller hoped that this might have been positive development, reporting in the *Maryborough and Gympie Evangelist*,

We feel glad to see that the barrier which has so much marred the progress in the work so far removed. And we sincerely hope that the day is not far distant when they will unite with us, and thus build up a strong Baptised Church for Christ here in Gympie.⁵⁸

The Churches of Christ (or Disciples, as they were then commonly known), had commenced in Gympie early in 1887 when their prominent evangelist, David Ewers, had visited the town. He built on local interest initiated by Godson and his long-standing colleague, Mrs Jane Cane (both formerly of Maryborough), who had read some of Ewer's documents, and held their first 'Disciples' meeting in August 1886.⁵⁹

Ewer's visit was short, but it resulted in many conversions to the Disciples. The momentum was maintained by other evangelists who followed in rapid succession. This was particularly so with the abrasive American, Austin Mordaunt, who arrived in mid-1887 and caused a stir with his outspoken statements in the local press. This negative reputation was no deterrent to success, however, because it was reported that he conducted at least two baptism services, attracting crowds of up to 2,000 people.⁶⁰

The Disciples movement had begun in the USA in the early 1800s emerging out of Presbyterian backgrounds, with a parallel movement in the United Kingdom originating in 1842 with a Baptist background. They appeared in South Australia in 1847, and have since been known more generally in this country as 'Churches of Christ'. By the

⁵⁶ GT 21 Feb 1889 p 3 This article contains a full report of the meeting to form the church.

⁵⁷ MGEv Feb 1889 p 3

⁵⁸ MGEv March 1889 p 3

⁵⁹ Graeme Chapman, *No Other Foundation* (Volume 2): III. Growth, Development and Challenge: B. Mission., 1993 Typescript - on line - n.p.

⁶⁰ Geoff Risson and Craig Brown, *The Church from the Paddock* (Churches of Christ, Brisbane 2nd Edition p 22), states that there was some form of Disciples church in Gympie from 1877 onwards, of which little is known. This may have been the first appearance of the Disciples in Queensland (p 2), but the first stable work began in 1882 when they took over a German Baptist church at Zillmans Waterholes (Geebung) (see Melvin Williams, 'The German Baptist Church at Zillman Waterholes', *Queensland Baptist Forum* No 48 April 2001, pp 3-7). Ewers visited Gympie in 1887 to expand the initial efforts of Godson and Cane the previous year. It also stated that there were a number of baptisms with crowds of 1500 and 2000 people, but there is no report of these in the local press! See also Edward Roberts-Thomson, *Baptists and Disciples of Christ* London: Carey Kingsgate Press, 1951.

1880s in Gympie, it was clear that some people in the community regarded them as a branch of the broader Baptist movement.⁶¹ It may have been in this context that Rev WT Godson had interested himself in the church.

However, over the years, the distinctions between the two bodies became clearer. Although there have been

sporadic discussions between the two groups as well as occasional tension, there has never been any kind of merger or union. In recent decades, both of the denominations have changed in considerable measure losing much of their earlier distinctives, and the old issues, of which current leaders and members of both contemporary churches are largely unaware, rarely surface.⁶²

Not surprisingly, relationships between the two groups in Gympie had not been smooth, especially given the strong-minded views expressed by some of the earliest adherents and leaders of the Disciples. Later, Weller observed that,

[S]everal parties with various creeds had been posing as Baptists, yet were at variance with one another. Their close communion principles, and their plain statement that baptism is essential to salvation made them many enemies.⁶³

This situation had a negative impact on the Baptists, and Weller said,

Frequently we overhear untruthful remarks in reference to our doctrine and practice from people who do not take trouble to enquire what we preach.

Fortunately, he was able to add,

The opposition to us is gradually dying down, however, from the fact that we are recognised by other Christian Churches as the only legitimate Baptists, who preach the simple gospel of the grace of God, and teach a loving obedience in the form of total immersion.⁶⁴

In any case, Weller had secured the use of the Disciples' building for baptisms on a couple of occasions, and hoped that this was a sign of better times to come. Feeling now that barriers had been removed, he hoped for a possibility of a united Baptist activity in the town where such a witness was so needed.⁶⁵ However, this vision did not materialise—at least not immediately, and when it did years later, it was yet again another unusual situation.⁶⁶ Meanwhile, there were reports of increased Baptist congregations, baptisms and additions to the membership.⁶⁷

So, for the time being, the two groups continued their own separate paths. The Baptists stood in need of building of their own—not only to conduct baptisms but also to house increased attendances at services. While trying to procure a building, they continued to use public facilities such as the Rechabite and Oddfellows Halls. But there were limitations involved in using these public facilities. In January 1889, Weller commented on one of the practical issues they encountered. He told readers of *The Evangelist* that they had added backs to the seats in the building to provide a little more comfort for the worshippers, and explained,

But as the hall is not our own, we cannot of course make improvements that are necessary for our requirements as a Church. We are, therefore, making strong efforts to raise funds for the erection of a building of our own.⁶⁸

They were faced with considerable bureaucratic difficulties securing official ownership of land.⁶⁹ But late in 1889 hopes were raised when it was announced that a suitable church building (in an unspecified site) had become available.⁷⁰ But just about as soon as that offer was made, it was withdrawn, leaving the church disappointed. But very soon after, another site became available, located on Caledonian Hill, and sufficient funds were promised to

⁶¹ Eg, GT 7 Feb 1888 refers to the Disciples leader at the time, Mordaunt, as a 'Campbellite Baptist'.

⁶² see David Parker, 'Baptist Relations with Churches of Christ (QB Forum Aug 2006 No 63 pp 3-8).

⁶³ MGEv Jan 1889

⁶⁴ MGEv Jan 1889

⁶⁵ MGEv March 1889

⁶⁶ It involved a long-standing Baptist lay-preacher suddenly switching from the Disciples church to be the main force in forming another Baptist church.

⁶⁷ MGEv May 1889 p 3; on 12 April 1889, there were 6 baptisms at the Disciples' Church.

⁶⁸ MGEv Jan 1889 p 3.

⁶⁹ MGEv Aug 1889 p 3

⁷⁰ MGEv Nov 1889 p 3

acquire it. There was also a (vain) hope that funds from the sale of a church closing in Brisbane (in Fortescue Street) might have been available to assist!⁷¹

While there were lots of signs of advance, much of it due to Weller's own efforts, he frequently noted in the local Baptist newspaper the difficulties that he had encountered in a community based on the gold mining industry. Not surprisingly, he found that people had an obsession with making their worldly fortune, rather than seeking the kingdom of God.⁷²

It had been a roller-coaster ride for Weller and his people. He could look back to the time of his arrival when he had 'commenced in a very quiet way', although he reported, '[we] have steadily increased all round.'⁷³ After a few months he was able to rejoice in improved church life with baptisms and vigorous activities of the church organisations, as well as the good reception that the monthly newspaper had received.⁷⁴

Yet he remembered that 'The earliest prospects were by no means encouraging' with opposition and few resources, especially because of the negative impact of the Disciples church, which meant that the sect 'known as the Baptists were regarded by many here as a bigoted lot of people.'⁷⁵ But through prayer, trust and faithful witness, he could say, 'we have received many tokens to cheer and encourage notwithstanding our many trials'⁷⁶

But as the year came to close, he felt that they were still 'striving hard against great odds and even considerable prejudice'⁷⁷ which created a 'dark time of trial, anxiety and patient waiting.'⁷⁸ He wrote,

[W]hilst we are advocates of *water* for the use of religious doctrine dear to us, yet it seemed sometimes as though we could not survive the *inundation* of cold and bitter opposition, and sceptical criticism which we have had to pass through. The most unkind statements have been hurled at us by thoughtless light-headed observers. But the glorious wave of Free grace teaching for all men, has carried us on to success, and will land all believers eventually on the shores of Christ's Kingdom.*(emphasis added)*⁷⁹

His final column in *The Evangelist* was up-beat, with cheery reflections on the year that was ending and the varied experiences of his flock. He made an appeal for the well-off to contribute generously to the building program, the plans of which were already before the church members. He could report steady progress, despite the pressures, and called upon their mature faith:

Men and Brethren, we are followers of no cunningly devised fable or manmade formulars (sic). We are followers of the broad liberal-hearted loving Christ, who came bringing Salvation to all who believed in His name. We are a plain people, with a plain Gospel, and we seek ever to proclaim the Gospel Truth as it is in Him, who came to uplift the fallen and to establish a universal Christian Brotherhood of men.⁸⁰

However, in the end, it all became too much for him. With reports of health issues, he withdrew, announcing his resignation in December 1889.⁸¹ He preached his last sermon on Sunday 19 January 1890 at the Rechabite Hall, with a sermon based on John 14:16,17 entitled, 'Solid Comfort'.⁸² The service was attended by representatives from all the other denominations. A farewell meeting was held in the Primitive Methodist Church, Red Hill, on Monday 27 January 1890⁸³ where he was presented with a silver plate, a purse of sovereigns, and an illuminated address in appreciation for his 16 months of outstanding service.⁸⁴

He soon found another appointment, this time at the Hendra (Clayfield) church on the northern outskirts of Brisbane, where he spent the next five years, and married Emily Louisa Harlen. Later, he had a varied and successful ministry in several locations, capped off by a lengthy period at Nundah (1914-30). In particular, he served for many years as the senior military chaplain for which he was awarded an OBE and ED. He died in 1939.

⁷¹ GT 22 Oct 1889 p 3; GT 21 Jan 1890 p 3; QB Jan 1890 p 5

⁷² MGEv July 1889 p 3

⁷³ MGEv Jan 1889 p 3.

⁷⁴ MGEv March 1889

⁷⁵ MGEv Jan 1889

⁷⁶ MGEv Sept 1889

⁷⁷ MGEv Oct 1889

⁷⁸ MGEv Nov 1889

⁷⁹ MGEv Oct 1889

⁸⁰ MGEv Dec 1889 p 3

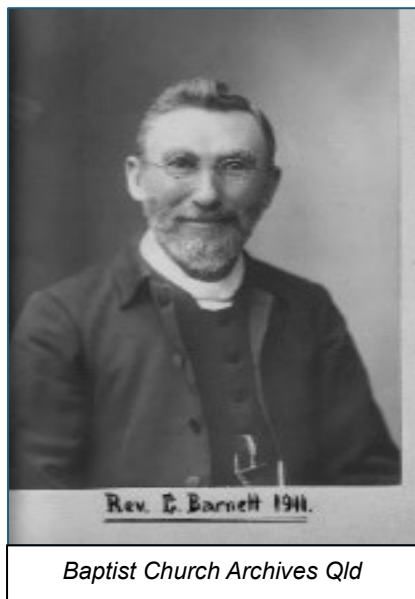
⁸¹ GT 18 Jan 1890 p 3, GM 17 Jan 1890 p 3; GT 21 Jan 1890 p 3

⁸² GT 18 Jan 1890 p 3; MGEv Feb 1890 p 3

⁸³ GM 29 Jan 1890 p 2

⁸⁴ MGEv Feb 1890 p 3

Rev Ezekiel Barnett 1890



A replacement pastor was soon announced, Rev Ezekiel Barnett. He preached first on Sunday 20 April 1890, and his topics were ‘Religious persistency’ and ‘The greatest question in the Bible.’⁸⁵ After an initial trial period, he accepted an invitation to remain in the town. He said he expected his stay ‘would not be a brief one’, but that would prove not to be true!⁸⁶

Barnett was born in Carmarthen, Wales in 1856, and trained privately for the ministry while still under 20 years of age. He migrated to New Zealand in 1880 at the request of Thomas Spurgeon, and served at Cambridge before moving to New South Wales, and then to Queensland in 1889 (at the suggestion of William Whale) for the sake of his health.

He was formally installed at a tea meeting and public meeting chaired by the mayor of Gympie on 12 June 1890. There were two outstanding visitors—Rev William Poole, President of the Baptist Association, and Queensland’s popular first missionary to Bengal, Miss Martha Plested.⁸⁷ They had addressed the church services on the previous weekend. There had also been a series of other meetings with powerful presentations of the Baptist Lady Zenana missionary work in Bengal which specialised in ministry to the secluded inner area of houses for women in the Indian sub-continent. This ministry of Miss Plested, who appeared in local costume,

displayed artefacts and sang hymns from that area, was enthusiastically supported by Queensland Baptists for more than 30 years.⁸⁸

Barnett made a very strong beginning to his ministry, especially during August and September with a series of apologetics lectures in the Oddfellows Hall, which he called ‘evenings with sceptics’. At the end of the series, it was reported that attendance had been good, ‘the lectures most able and instructive, and proved the lecturer to be a man of talent and ability.’⁸⁹

But then it all came to an end. Barnett too found he could not cope. He preached his final sermons in the Oddfellows Hall on 16 November 1890, and he moved to Toowoomba.⁹⁰ His personal effects were sold by auction at his Crescent Road home on 18 December.⁹¹ There were no more reports in the local press after August 1890, and in December, the Baptist Home Mission announced that the work had been closed at the end of November, the church was disbanded and the land sold.⁹²

It must have been a severe disappointment for the local people, the pastors, and those far-sighted leaders of the Baptist Association who had invested so much human and material resources in this mission, the second attempt to establish a Baptist church in ‘Queensland’s Golden City.’ Years later, this setback was still remembered—a report in the *Gympie Times* spoke of the ‘stress of circumstances’ that had caused the work to fail.⁹³

Later Barnett served for short periods at Toowoomba, Mount Morgan, and Lanefield, before a lengthy pastorate at Nundah (where he was succeeded by Rev A G Weller). At different times, he was President and Secretary of the Baptist Association, but suffered severe rheumatism in later life which seriously interrupted his ministry. He died after a long period of poor health in 1923.

A church established 1897—

There was one brief lingering sign of Baptist life in Gympie after the collapse of the Weller-Barnett church. It occurred in May 1891, when a strange notice appeared in the local press under the heading: ‘**Cornwall (one and all)**’ (emphasis original), and it announced that Mr T U Symonds, a ‘Cornish Baptist’, would preach in the Rechabite

⁸⁵ GT 19 April 1890 p 3

⁸⁶ GM 13 June 1890 p 3

⁸⁷ GM 13 June 1890; GT 10 June 1890 p 2 and 14 June 1890 p 3

⁸⁸ See David Parker, *The Martha Plested Story*, (Baptist Union of Queensland Department of Mission 1986), ADEB p 310f. GT 7 June 1890 p 2.

⁸⁹ *The Week* Brisbane 4 Oct 1890 p 17

⁹⁰ GT 15 Nov 1890

⁹¹ GT 13 Dec 1890 p 2

⁹² QF Dec 1890

⁹³ GT 4 Nov 1899

Hall on Sunday 10th May, morning and evening (with a preceding open-air meeting), and that a collection would be taken in aid of the 'Nanango Mission.'



Symonds, who had arrived in Queensland in 1885, was a Baptist lay-missioner based in Nanango (in the South Burnett area about 135 km from Gympie) where he was employed in a local business. Informal services had begun in early 1890,⁹⁴ and a church was formed in June 1890 with Mr Symonds as pastor. In addition, a block of ground was donated at Coolabunia where a building was opened in December 1890. Services and other meetings took place in many other different locations around the large district. This outreach was well supported by the Baptist Association, and had early connections with Jireh Baptist Church, with which Mr Symonds had previously been in fellowship.

Soon after his visit to Gympie, Symonds moved on from that area to become an effective ordained Baptist minister who served in several locations around the state. He was particularly well known for his 15-year leadership of the Queensland Baptist Home Mission as its initial full-time Superintendent. He died on 12 July 1937 at the age of 74.⁹⁵

Evidently, some of the members of the Gympie church, which had officially closed about six months earlier, were still meeting informally on the occasion of his visit, but there is no other record of any other services or preachers. There is no sign of any continued activity, although there were no doubt still Baptist people in the district. In fact, a history of the church written in 1927 records that some of the 'original Baptists'—referring probably to the second phase around 1890—were still in fellowship.

Even so, it would be a period of seven biblical years until there was another attempt to establish a Baptist church in Gympie. By now town-status had been proclaimed, and there had considerable development, economic diversification and unionisation. Severe flooding had again taken place, especially in 1893, the worst ever, which reached a height of 25.45 metres (higher than the 2022 figure of 22.9 metres). Severe economic depression ensued.

Mr J H Bowring

The final Baptist initiative began late in 1897, and revolved around the ministry of Mr Joseph H Bowring (sometimes Bowering) who appears to have moved to the town earlier that year. He was instrumental, with the assistance of the Baptist pastor at Maryborough, in commencing a third version of Baptist church, the one which finally became permanent and has survived to the present.

Bowring probably arrived in Queensland around 1880, but he made his first recorded appearance in Christian circles in 1886, and soon became active in lay ministries of various kinds, especially temperance work. He was associated with the Baptists and the Primitive Methodists in Petrie Terrace and Rosalie, closely connected and densely popular inner-city areas of Brisbane. He was mainly known for his preaching, but along with his wife and son, he also often sang at Christian meetings. Another of his activities was as a leader and preacher for the 'Mission to the Unemployed' through which he conducted services and offered welfare at the old Immigration Centre in George Street during 1892. He was a regular participant in the work of Baptist (Lay) Preachers' Society.

At Petrie Terrace Baptist Church, he was Sunday School Superintendent, and on the building committee when the new church building was opened in 1895. In the same year, he went 'out west to preach the word of truth to the men in the remote parts of the colony.'⁹⁶ During all this time, he owned different properties in the Rosalie area and was involved some legal action in relation to them at various times.

But he (and another friend from Petrie Terrace, Mr T Belotti) moved to Gympie early in 1897, perhaps to catch a boom in the gold mining industry, but mainly to engage in Christian ministry. He immediately became a regular weekly preacher at the Disciples Church, based at their building in Crescent Road. This is the same church that Rev A G Weller had used for some baptisms eight years earlier, and with which he hoped there would be a good working relationship. This was probably the only suitable church in Gympie at the time for Bowring to attend, and his preaching ministry was no doubt welcomed cordially. He was still preaching at this church in August 1897 when their tenth anniversary celebrations were held. His musical talents were also put to good use. But suddenly, only a

⁹⁴ QB March 1890 p 10

⁹⁵ See RW (Bill) Hughes, *Queensland for Christ: The story of the Queensland Baptist Home Mission 1883-1983* (Baptist Historical Society of Queensland, 2005).

⁹⁶ QF Aug 1896 p 96

couple of months later, on 3 October 1897, he is listed as leading newly established Baptist services advertised to be held in the Congregational Church.⁹⁷

Church constituted

These services continued in the weeks following with various visiting speakers, including the Rev J K McIntyre who conducted a communion service on 7 November 1897 with an attendance of 17. The following day saw a tea meeting, chaired by Mr Bellotti⁹⁸ and attended by Rev Charles Boyall of Maryborough Baptist Church, at the conclusion of which 11 believers formed a church. Mr Boyall was named as honorary pastor and Mr Bowring as the local leader. Some additional people indicated their interest in baptism and church membership. In following months, activities such as a Sunday School, Band of Hope and a Ladies Sewing Class were commenced.

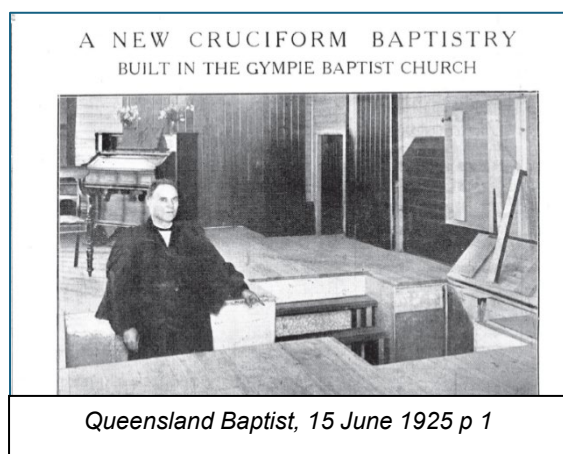
Accommodation was difficult due to a shortage of public halls available for rental. The Oddfellows Hall used for a period of time, as well as the Miners Hall in Crown Road.⁹⁹ This difficulty led to an early move to look for a block of land upon which to erect a building. This was achieved in early 1898 when a property was purchased at No 11 Apollonian Vale.¹⁰⁰ Meanwhile services were conducted regularly, with Bowring taking many of them, but also several were led by pastors and other preachers visiting from Brisbane

Progress was rapid, and soon plans were developed for a church building. A structure, 38 x 30 feet in size, was opened on 5 November 1899 by Rev F G Buckingham of Ipswich and Mr David Webster (the biscuit manufacturer) who was president of the Baptist Association. Local ministers also took part in the service.¹⁰¹ There was a Tea Meeting on 7 November with Mr Bowring providing some songs. Special mention was made of his efforts in bringing the church into existence. Mr Boyall said that except 'for his ardent efforts, there would have been no Baptist Church in Gympie that day'¹⁰²

It was reported that the cost of the land was £30, (purchased from a Mrs McCathie), and that the building cost £146, plus extras. There was an overdraft of £75, for which a local family stood as guarantors. It was a simple building, seating 120 people, with no vestry or baptistry, but additions were made in later years, and in the 1920s, a novel cruciform-shaped baptistry was installed.¹⁰³ A hall was another addition.

There was an unusual challenge issued at the church opening by the honorary pastor, Rev Charles Boyall. He stressed that this was now the

only Baptist church of Gympie, and therefore was now established as a home for the Baptist(s) and he urged all who desired to be true to their principles to *come home* (emphasis original).¹⁰⁴



It is not clear what this meant, unless it was directed to Baptists who might have been associated with other churches in the town, but more likely it was directed at the Disciples and their lingering impact.

Nine years earlier, Rev A G Weller had reported on the prejudice against the Baptist that he had found upon his arrival in the town, a situation which he believed was utterly unjustified, and one which he strove to correct.

There had also been the misunderstanding caused by the Disciples with their divisive and dogmatic views on baptism and close communion. They had caused considerable misunderstanding and confusion in the town, and the presence of various splinter groups. But Weller had noticed gradual

⁹⁷ This was the original building, erected in 1868 on Palatine Hill (GT 8 Oct 1870 p 2), which was replaced by the Jamieson Memorial Church in 1911 (now a Lutheran church).

⁹⁸ QB Oct 1897; GT 9 Nov 1897 p 3

⁹⁹ GT 2 April 1898 This report refers to both the use of the Oddfellows Hall in Red Hill Road, and 'the Crown-road hall' which may have been the Welsh Church, but there was also Miners Union Hall on the southern corner of the intersection of Crown, Woolgar and Stanley Streets.

¹⁰⁰ GT 2 April 1898 p 2. The name 'Caledonian Hill' was used at the time, but the location was usually known later as Apollonian Vale.

¹⁰¹ GT 4 Nov 1899, 14 Nov 1899

¹⁰² QB Dec 1898

¹⁰³ QB June 1925 p 1

¹⁰⁴ QB Dec 1898

positive recognition of the Baptists as the legitimate witnesses to this branch of the faith.

He explained,

We preach Christ, and on the acceptance of the merits of his atonement, we feel it a loving duty to follow him through the water. Thus it will be seen we do not believe in a merited salvation, but grace and grace only. We invite all believers in Him to unite with us around the Lord's Table; so that, as His redeemed, we may sit together and feast on the symbols of His dear love.¹⁰⁵

CHURCHES—Methodist, Rev. F. T. Lloyd, Rev. W. H. Harrison. Presbyterian, Rev. J. M'Intyre. Church of England, Rev. C. A. Griffith, B.A., Rev. C. E. Hughes, and Rev. A. E. Henry. Roman Catholic, Revs. M. Horan and J. O'Reilly. Disciples of Christ, Crescent road. Welsh Church, Crown road. Plymouth Brethren, Mary street. Particular Baptist, Red Hill. True Baptist, Caledonian Hall, J. H. Bowring.

Pugh's Almanac 1900, p 740

But there could also have been another group in Boyall's sights because the 1900 edition of *Pugh's Almanac* did list two Baptist churches in Gympie, a 'Particular Baptist' at Red Hill with no leader stated, and a 'True Baptist' at 'Caledonian Hall' (sic) under the leadership of J H Bowring. Earlier issues of the *Almanac* had listed the Particular Baptist Church even for the period before the formation of the Boyall-Bowring church, which may have been an inaccurate relic of earlier days. There was no other record of this group, which could well have held the stricter views that Boyall referenced.



Rev V Bowring
(Baptist Church
Archives Qld)

Nevertheless, optimism for the main Baptist cause was high. A report in the *Queensland Baptist* for March 1898 said that 'the work was going well.' Even though '[t]he difficulties experienced 10 years ago are aggravated by the failure of the effort then made,' it was confident that 'a glorious work is started which shall last as the hills.'¹⁰⁶

The new church continued to develop steadily, but in just under two years, it was announced that the Bowrings were leaving the town. A farewell was held on 26 April 1900, at which there were glowing expressions of gratitude to the family for their important contribution to the church, including Mrs Bowring's ministry as organist and leader of the work amongst women.

Mr Bowring was appointed as a temporary pastor for the Baptist Church at Beaudesert, after which he returned to Brisbane, taking a prominent lead once again in the work of the Baptist Lay Preachers' Association. He died in 1930 at the age of 69. One of his grandsons was Rev Victor C Bowring (b 4 Oct 1916), who served two separate terms as pastor of the

Gympie Baptist Church. He died on 7 February 1987 after a very effective period of 17 ½ years as the final superintendent of the Queensland Baptist Home Mission.

Following the departure of the Bowrings from Gympie, there were many visiting preachers, including officers of the Baptist Association and other Brisbane pastors. Finally Rev Robert Robertson of Victoria was appointed pastor and began his ministry in May 1901. Coming from a remarkable family of ministers and evangelists, he had been serving as an agent of Evangelistic Association of Victoria conducting missions at various Queensland churches.¹⁰⁷

¹⁰⁵ MGEv 1/1/ Jan 1889 p 3

¹⁰⁶ QB March 1898 p 41

¹⁰⁷ Laurie Rowston, 'Joshua Robertson' story' (privately circulated paper, nd) from Baptist Union of Victoria Archives, 2026; Peter Young, 'Rev. Joshua Robertson: a paper read to the Baptist Historical Society of NSW', 16 Oct 1980).



Baptist Church, 11 Apollonian Vale (Baptist Church Archives Qld) Current Site (29 Dec 2022)

He led the church effectively for almost six years before moving to Sandgate in 1907 and marrying Gympie school teacher and church organist, Miss F Daniell (on 7 July 1907). His son, Joshua, was also a Baptist pastor (and had served also at Sandgate). Both father and son were inaugural students of the new Queensland Baptist (Theological) College when it opened in 1904.

Conclusion

So finally, the third attempt at planting a Baptist church in Gympie was marked with success. This church has continued until the present day, under the leadership of almost 30 pastors. Over the years numerous outstations were also established in the surrounding districts, and various ministries were established, including an innovative full-time child care centre in the early 1970s. The church reached its peak membership of nearly 100 in 1925, with high levels again in the 1980s and in recent years.



2-4 Horseshoe Bend (Baptist Church Archives); 133 Corella Road

There have also been three locations for this church—first at 11 Apollonian Vale from 1899 until 1961 when the building was found to be unsafe and too expensive to fix.¹⁰⁸ A new location was then found at 2-4 Horseshoe Bend, and put into use in 1961. Finally, the present property at 133 Corella Street was opened in 2000.

And so Baptists eventually established themselves in ‘the town that saved Queensland’, even if it did take three attempts over a 30-year period to do so! It was perhaps not surprising that it took this long. The town’s social, industrial and economic history meant that the Baptists had to cope with all of the volatility that characterised it. Then there was the weather, the small size and divided nature of the local Baptist community, the sheer number of other denominations who had established themselves in the town, and the limitations of denominational support for the venture. In the circumstances, their efforts were nothing short of remarkable.

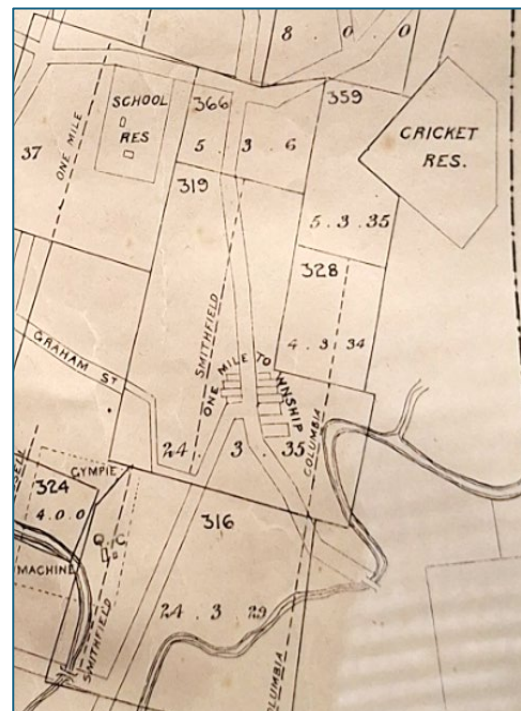
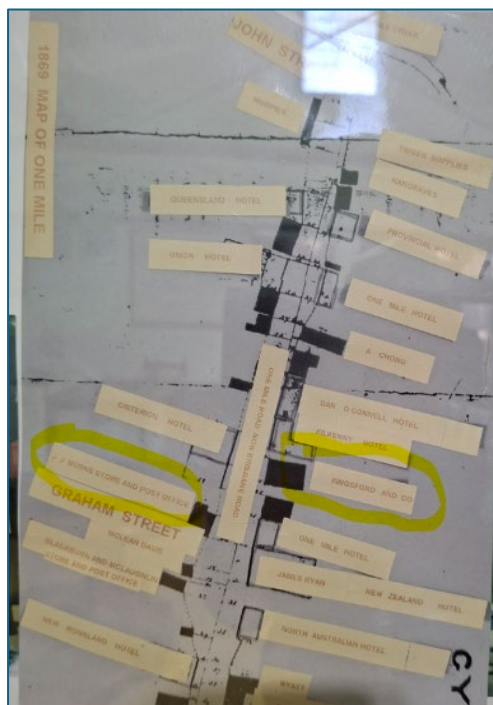
¹⁰⁸ The site of the actual church building at the front of the block is still vacant; the hall (converted) remains at the rear.

Appendix: The Location of the One Mile Baptist Church



42-44 Red Hill Road Gympie (Google street view, 20 June 2026)

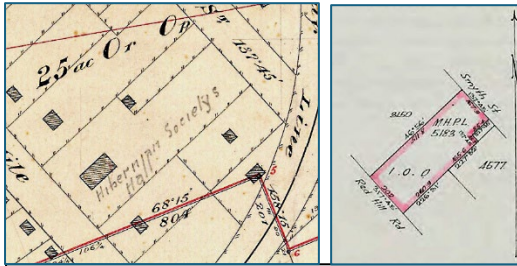
The location of the One Mile Baptist property is most likely to be identified as the current 42-44 Red Hill Road. This was the site of the Hibernian Hall up to 1947, after which the block was subdivided for housing.¹⁰⁹ It is approximately 650 metres from the One Mile Village area, which centred on the section of Brisbane Road (formerly One Mile Road) between the intersections with Phoenix and Graham Streets. This latter area is seen on the 1869 Stuart map of the One Mile and on the Map of Gympie Goldfields, 1881, both on display at the Gympie Mining and Historical Museum.



Stuart Map of One Mile (1869 (portion); Gympie Goldfields Map 1881 (both on display at Gympie Mining and Historical Museum)

The Hall site is about 80 metres in elevation, 30 metres higher than the main village area. This location now seems quite a distance from the original One Mile village. However, maps of the day indicate that 'One Mile Road' was used for the current Red Hill Road area.

¹⁰⁹ Gympie Libraries, email 22 May 2026.



Images of diagrams of the Bull-Baptist-Hibernian block at 42-44 Red Hill Road, supplied by Museum of Lands, Mapping and Surveying, 2026

Some early maps show the block as containing 0.2.0 acres, which is a calculated, not a measured figure, as indicated by the term 'bal'.

The Daniell-Pyne land application and an advertisement for a local school meeting describe the Baptist site as fronting One Mile Road, and measuring 100 ft wide and 200 ft deep in a north-easterly direction.¹¹⁰ This description matches the 42-44 Red Hill Road block in its original form.

The sale notice for Dr Bull's property defines it as 'on the Main Brisbane Road, *adjoining* the One Mile Township.' Other reports also use the term '*near* the One Mile', indicating that it was not in the main business area of Phoenix-Graham Streets. This also agrees with press reports of the 1870 flood which state that water extended

from the Kingsford store to 'a considerable distance up the hill on which the Baptist Chapel stands.' The Kingsford Store, as marked on the Stuart map, is located at approximately the current 16 Brisbane Road, on the eastern side between Phoenix and Graham Streets.



Detail of Gympie Map showing location of railway crossing, Hibernian Hall, Presbyterian Church and Oddfellows Hall, Red Hill Road. Larger section of same map below showing Red Hill area (left) and One Mile commercial district (right) with School, Phoenix Street and Graham Street (name obscured) (Queensland State Archives Town of Gympie DR96998 1934 Sheet 2)

Another contemporary reference mentions that the water reached toward the Presbyterian (now Uniting) church site, a further 250 metres up the road, and considerably higher than the Baptist site.¹¹¹

After the 1870 flood, the Bull-Baptist block was reported as being taken over by the Hibernians. The only site in the area known to

have been occupied by this organisation was the same current 42-44 Red Hill Road location.

The Hibernian Society began operations in Gympie in 1872 as a social and community club for the Irish people. A benefit society was attempted a little later, but these initial efforts were short-lived, although there was success in due course.¹¹²

There are some references to the use by the Hibernian Society of a temporary hall further down Red Hill Road towards One Mile below the later railway crossing. However, these appear to be confused with another building, which was said to be 'constructed of saplings and palings.'¹¹³ There is no other information about any such building



or location. This quote may in fact reference a report about a court case regarding ownership of different property,

¹¹⁰ GT 31 March 1869

¹¹¹ GT 9 March 1870

¹¹² (GT 17 June 1876 p 3).

¹¹³ *Gympie's Jubilee 1867-1917; Gympie in its cradle days* (Gympie: Gympie and District Historical Society, 1985 p 39).

described as a humpy built of saplings and palings supported by props and then in a poor condition.¹¹⁴ This does not match the descriptions of the Bull-Baptist property which was of a substantial nature.

During the latter part of 1872, the Hibernian Society was reported to be using a temporary hall in Red Hill, presumably the Bull-Baptist Church building. In early 1873, a search began for a suitable permanent site. However, it was decided that the existing location was the best. So tenders were let and a new hall opened in February 1874 at a cost of £400.¹¹⁵ However, there is no mention of any building already on the site or any demolition thereof.



*Hibernian Australasian Catholic Benefit Society (HACB) Hall, 42-44 Red Hill Road
(Historical Sketch of Gympie, 1867-1927
edited by A.L. Stumm, W.C.
Woolgar, and C.S. Trudgian, pp 94-96, 97)*

END

¹¹⁴ GM 31 Oct 1879 p 2

¹¹⁵ GT 18 Feb 1874, 18 April 1874